making civilizational inroads till the voyages of Admiral Zheng He in the fifteenth century.

The cultural impact of this era lives on in South-East Asia. It may be most obvious in the Hindu island of Bali, but, throughout the region, the influence of ancient India is alive in the names of places and people as well as the large number of Indian-derived words used in everyday speech. The national languages of both Malaysia and Indonesia are called ‘Bahasa’, and both are full of Sanskrit words. Indeed, the name itself is derived from the Sanskrit word *bhasha* meaning language. From Myanmar to Vietnam, Buddhism remains the dominant religion. To this day, the coronation of the king of Buddhist Thailand and other royal ceremonies must be done by Hindu priests. There are more shrines to the god Brahma in Bangkok than in all of India.

India’s influence is civilizational rather than narrowly religious, and it extends all the way to the Korean peninsula. The prestige associated with ancient Indian civilization, for example, is recalled in the national myth of Korea. According to the *Samguk Yusa*,[9] Princess Huh Hwang-ok of Ayodhya sailed all the way to Korea to marry King Suro in the fourth century AD. They had ten sons and together founded Korea’s earliest dynasty. The Gimhae Kim clan claims to be direct descendants of this union and remains influential (former President Kim Dae Jung was from this clan).

It is amazing how the essence of a civilization can survive over large distances in space and time. Watching the Ramayana performed in the Javanese style against a backdrop of the ninth-century Prambanan temples in Java, one is struck by how the landscape of a far-off time and a faraway land is evoked. The stone temples transform themselves from scene to scene—sometimes they recall the rocky outcrops of Kishkindha, sometimes Ravan’s palace in Lanka. A couple of hours’ drive away, the sunset seen from the top of the Buddhist stupa at Borobodur retains its magical effect even if Buddhist chants have now been replaced by the Islamic call to prayer.